However, whether such conciliatory approach has been effective or not is a question worth exploring more. Musazai found India's conciliatory approach of treating Afghanistan as an independent, sovereign state as 'smart, right, and good'.[104] Partisan engagement, he argued, will be seen as a 'clear interference in our [Afghan] domestic affairs'.[105] Mahmoud Saikal, deputy foreign minister for economic affairs in 2005–06, also testified that an open-minded approach was remarkable.[106] Karzai often praised India's Afghanistan policy throughout his presidency. With the Afghan government supporting a conciliatory line, New Delhi did not change policy course eventually by deepening engagement with factions outside the government.

'Karzai is no Massoud'

The partisans, throughout Karzai's presidency, wanted to deepen engagement with his opponents to show that India had not given up on them. Pessimistic about Pakistan's role in Afghanistan and Kabul's capacity to effectively counter the Afghan Taliban, partisans viewed Karzai's opponents as India's natural partners. By not supporting them, according to this advocacy, India was burning a bridge, as was evident from Wali Massoud's criticism of India's pro-Karzai tilt. If the conciliators treated Afghanistan as a weak but sovereign state, the partisans advocated independent and stronger relations with extra-governmental actors (in this case, ironically, most of Karzai's opponents were part of the government). If the conciliators drew conceptual strength from the principle of sovereignty and the need for stability, the partisans delved into breathtaking anti-Pakistan realpolitik. The Pakistan army's determination for strategic depth in Afghanistan, partisans argued, would never allow Afghanistan to develop as a strong and stable country. For instance, Narayanan told the US ambassador to India in a private conversation that 'Pakistan is outsourcing its problems to Afghanistan … and that democracy could prevail against terrorism rather than for the reasons Pakistan thinks.'[107] Unlike the conciliators who viewed Afghanistan on its own merits, the partisans nurtured an unhealthy obsession with Pakistan. Afghanistan for them was not neutral territory.